will follow. Place your cordon along these paths. One party should come with me and we will head straight for the target house. If we take three Companies, they should be adequate to do the job.' Hold your horses, I thought to myself. Who is commanding here? After all, if things went wrong, it is I who would be answerable. Jameel, I think, sensed my apprehensions.

'Sahib, please. We must go and go in now. Morning will be too late.'

'Why?'

'They have been there the entire day,' reasoned Jameel. 'They have been seen by others. A quick meal and the moment it's dark, they will move out.'

'What makes you say so?'

'Sahib,' he replied, with a look of resignation, 'I was a militant myself, once upon a time. I know. Trust me.'

So now I was to trust a militant! Someone I had met only a few hours earlier. And on his advice, launch an operation on questionable intelligence, with darkness only a few hours away, which in itself was against conventional military wisdom. Could we be walking into a trap? My Adjutant, Rehan, was doing a Bernard à la *Yes Minister*. He had supplied all kinds of bits and pieces of information—the number of houses in the village, its demographics, name of the *mukdam* or village elder and a long list of suspects—but nothing that enabled me to make a decision. I looked out of the window at the cloudy, thunderous sky.

No inspiration there.

I looked once again at this dubious duo. Farooq was at his fidgety best. Jameel sat quietly, looking at me; ready to answer my questions and help me to make up my mind. I saw in him a professional, with a steely resolve and a sense of commitment. The intelligence was tenuous, true, but at least it

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